

Baldock’s silver medal, issued in gold, silver or lead, according to rank, to all those who fought (on the winning side) at Seringapatam in 1799.

One of the first of my forebears to seek his fortune in India took part in the assault on Seringapatam and it made him a rich man (see illustrations). Eighteen-year-old Ensign Christopher Baldock’s share of the prize money as the most junior British officer present was £1000 – the equivalent today of at least £80,000 – which he doubled overnight in a game of cards. We still have Christopher’s silver medal in the family, as well as a copy of a letter written by his daughter describing the aftermath of the storming of Tipu’s fortress, part of which reads as follows:

> After the battle he [Christopher Baldock] was ordered to go into a tower to guard a part of the vast treasure taken from Tippoo Saib. He told my mother that he stood all night in the very centre of the tower, close all around him were small bags of a sort of calico tied up at the mouth. They reached up to his armpits. He stood there all night trying to keep awake with both arms spread out on the bags. He had barely room to stand in the middle … All the young officers receiving so much prize money, had nothing better to do than to gamble. One night he went with the others to a neighbouring